PAT SUMMITT

# DEFINITE DOZEN

## DISCUSSION GUIDE

For Players & Teams



Use one principle at a time. These questions are designed to help players and teams have honest conversations about standards, accountability, communication, culture and competitive excellence.

### THE 12 PRINCIPLES

1. **Respect Yourself and Others**
2. **Take Full Responsibility**
3. **Develop and Demonstrate Loyalty**
4. **Learn to be a Great Communicator**
5. **Discipline Yourself So No One Else Has To**
6. **Make Hard Work Your Passion**
7. **Don't Just Work Hard, Work Smart**
8. **Put the Team Before Yourself**
9. **Make Winning an Attitude**
10. **Be a Competitor**
11. **Change is a Must**
12. **Handle Success Like You Handle Failure**

Choose a principle, discuss it honestly, and leave with one observable action.

# #1: Respect Yourself and Others

1. Pat Summitt asked herself, "Could I work for me?" As a teammate, would you want yourself on your team? Why or why not?

2. What is one thing you do that earns your teammates' respect? What is one thing you could improve?

3. Think of a time you were frustrated with a teammate or coach. Did you respond respectfully? What could you do differently next time?

4. What are three ways a player can earn respect without being the best player, the loudest person, or a team captain?

5. What physical, mental, and emotional habits help you respect yourself and stay steady when pressure rises?

6. On a scale of 1-10, how much does your team act like "we" instead of "me"? What would move the score one point higher?

7. How can teammates hold each other accountable without embarrassing, insulting, or bossing each other around?

8. Which behavior hurts respect most on a team: gossip, eye-rolling, blaming, lateness, negativity, or something else? What can you do about it?

# #2: Take Full Responsibility

1. Think of a mistake you made in practice or competition. Did you make an excuse, blame someone else, or own it? What happened next?

2. What does taking full responsibility look like for a player before, during, and after competition?

3. What parts of your performance are in your control? What parts are not? Why is knowing the difference important?

4. How can you own your effort, attitude, and preparation even when playing time, calls, or decisions do not go your way?

5. When a teammate makes excuses, how can you encourage responsibility without attacking or embarrassing that person?

6. What is one excuse athletes commonly make? What would taking responsibility sound like instead?

7. Why is it powerful to own your mistakes when things go wrong and share the credit when things go right?

8. Who helps you stay accountable when you do not feel like doing what your team needs from you? How do they help?

# #3: Develop and Demonstrate Loyalty

1. What does loyalty mean to you as a teammate?

2. What makes you feel like a teammate truly has your back?

3. What does it look like to show loyalty to your teammates, your coach, and your team when things are difficult?

4. Is loyalty the same as agreeing with everything? How can you disagree respectfully and still support your team?

5. How should a loyal teammate respond when someone on the team is being talked about behind their back?

6. What does it mean to show loyalty before you expect loyalty from others? Give an example.

7. What small acts of kindness, support, or follow-through can show a teammate that you are there for them?

8. How can your team recognize players who consistently do the little things and put the team first?

# #4: Learn to be a Great Communicator

1. Think of a coach, teacher, teammate, or mentor who communicates really well. What makes that person effective?

2. What kind of communicator are you when things are going well? What changes when you are frustrated or under pressure?

3. What is one communication habit you need to improve: listening, speaking up, staying calm, asking questions, or something else?

4. Timing matters. Think of something you said at the wrong time. How did the timing affect what happened?

5. What makes it easier or harder for you to communicate honestly and respectfully with teammates and coaches?

6. When you give a teammate feedback, what makes it helpful instead of annoying, hurtful, or easy to ignore?

7. Rate your listening from 1-10. What one habit would make you a better listener this month?

8. If you do not understand your role or a coach's decision, how can you ask about it in a respectful and productive way?

# #5: Discipline Yourself So No One Else Has To

1. Talent matters, but discipline is something you can control. What is one goal where discipline helped you do something difficult?

2. Where are you most disciplined as an athlete? Where do you need to become more disciplined?

3. What is the difference between doing something because a coach makes you and doing it because you expect it from yourself?

4. What does it look like to do the right thing at practice even when a coach is not watching?

5. What habits help you stay disciplined with practice, school, sleep, food, recovery, or preparation?

6. How does your team feel when standards are enforced fairly and consistently? What happens when they are not?

7. Are your team's expectations clear? Which expectation is easiest for you to meet? Which is hardest?

8. What is one small habit you could repeat every day that would make you a better athlete or teammate?

# #6: Make Hard Work Your Passion

1. Life on a dairy farm helped shape Pat Summitt long before the championships. What experience in your life taught you how to work hard?

2. What does it mean to make hard work your passion instead of simply putting up with it?

3. How do you define hard work in practice, training, school, or competition?

4. Who has modeled hard work for you? What specific behavior did you learn from that person?

5. When have you had to work harder than the people around you? What did that experience teach you?

6. Think of a time you were tired but kept going because your team or your goal mattered. What helped you keep going?

7. Who is the hardest-working teammate or athlete you know? What do they consistently do that you could copy?

8. What hard thing is your team avoiding right now? How could everyone attack it together instead of avoiding it?

# #7: Don't Just Work Hard, Work Smart

1. Hard work aimed at the wrong target is still wasted effort. What does working smart mean for you as a player?

2. What can you do outside of practice to understand your sport, your position, or your role better?

3. What is one skill you repeat a lot? How could you make those repetitions more focused instead of just doing more of them?

4. How can you study an opponent without becoming intimidated, distracted, or tempted to simply copy them?

5. What can you learn from the smartest or most prepared players on your own team?

6. Where do you waste energy as an athlete: complaining, worrying, comparing yourself, losing focus, or something else?

7. Athletes build muscle memory through repetition. What team habit should you repeat until it becomes automatic?

8. What does success mean for you beyond the scoreboard? How can that definition help you make better choices?

# #8: Put the Team Before Yourself

1. Great teams often begin to feel like a family. What helps teammates trust each other and feel connected?

2. What team bonding experience has meant the most to you? Why did it bring people closer together?

3. Healthy teams still have conflict. How should teammates handle disagreements without letting them hurt the team?

4. What unspoken expectations do teammates have to meet to earn trust? Should any of those expectations be said out loud?

5. Who on your team does something important that does not always get noticed? What do they do for the team?

6. What is harder for you: accepting a role you did not want, sitting on the bench, or giving someone else credit? Why?

7. How can you support a teammate who is struggling even when helping them does not directly benefit you?

8. What is one decision you could make this week that puts the team ahead of your own convenience, ego, or recognition?

# #9: Make Winning an Attitude

1. What attitude does your team usually carry: expecting to win, just trying to survive, or expecting things to go wrong? What creates it?

2. What is the last meaningful win your team celebrated? Did you celebrate only the result, or also the habits that produced it?

3. Think of a painful loss or setback. How did you and your teammates respond in the next 24 hours?

4. Think of a tough moment your whole team faced. What did your team's attitude reveal during that moment?

5. What opportunity came from a past failure that you could not see at first?

6. What can you do as a player to bring positive energy without pretending everything is perfect?

7. How can your team practice winning habits before competition begins?

8. What is one daily behavior that would make winning an attitude instead of something you only think about on game day?

# #10: Be a Competitor

1. Does competition come naturally to you, or do you have to deliberately turn it on? How ready are you to compete on an average day?

2. What emotions come to mind when you hear the word competition? Which emotions help you, and which can hurt you?

3. Think of a strong rival or competitor from your past. How did that person or team make you better?

4. How have you changed your preparation or habits because you knew the competition would be strong?

5. Has a competitor ever pushed you through an obstacle without even knowing it? What did that teach you?

6. Who is an athlete or team you respect because of how they compete? What can you learn from them?

7. On a scale of 1-10, how competitive is your team as a whole? What would move it one point higher?

8. Competition reveals character. What has competition revealed about you that you needed to know?

# #11: Change is a Must

1. On a scale of 1-10, how comfortable are you personally with change?

2. How does your team react to change, such as a new role, lineup, position, strategy, or coach?

3. When a coach asks you to change something about how you play or prepare, what is your first reaction?

4. What major change in your role, habits, or team experience ultimately made you better?

5. What is one part of your game or attitude you know needs to change before someone else has to force the change?

6. Think of a change that did not work. Was the idea wrong, the timing wrong, the communication poor, or the effort incomplete?

7. Why is being willing to change necessary for your growth as an athlete and teammate?

8. What change would help your team right now that the players themselves can control?

# #12: Handle Success Like You Handle Failure

1. Pat Summitt believed that on the road to success, you never arrive. What does that mean to you as an athlete?

2. What can you learn from success that is different from what you learn from failure?

3. Think of a loss that made your team's next step clearer. What became obvious because things did not go your way?

4. Has success ever made you or your team too comfortable, overconfident, or less focused? How could you tell?

5. When things go well, who gets the credit? When things go badly, who gets the blame? What does that say about your team?

6. Which teaches you more personally: winning or losing? Why?

7. How can your team celebrate success without lowering the standard for what comes next?

8. How can teammates make it safe to make mistakes while still expecting everyone to learn, respond, and improve?

PUT THE DEFINITE DOZEN TO WORK

# Turn discussion into standards.

A simple team-meeting rhythm for moving from principle to action.

1. **PICK**
   Choose one principle that matters right now.

2. **DISCUSS**
   Give the team 10-15 minutes to answer honestly.

3. **DECIDE**
   Name one observable behavior that must change or continue.

4. **FOLLOW UP**
   Revisit the commitment at the next team meeting.

## 12-PRINCIPLE TEAM CHECK-IN

- ◯ 1. Respect Yourself and Others
- ◯ 2. Take Full Responsibility
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Strong culture is built when standards are discussed, modeled, reinforced and revisited.